

FEROCACTUS

spherical, perennial cactus. H 3ft (1m), S 2ft (60cm). Green stem, with 13–22 ribs, is fairly densely covered with curved, yellow-white spines. In summer bears funnel-shaped, yellow, rarely red, flowers, 2in (5cm) across, only on plants 10in (25cm) or more across. Z12–15 (min. 41°F/5°C)

F. cylindraceus, syn. *F. acanthodes*, illus. p.494.

F. hamatacanthus, syn. *Hamatocactus hamatacanthus*, illus. p.486.

F. latispinus. Slow-growing, flattened spherical, perennial cactus. H 8in (20cm), S 16in (40cm). Grayish-green stem, with 15–23 ribs, has broad, hooked, red or yellow spines. In summer, funnel-shaped, pale yellow, white, purple, or red flowers are borne on plants over 4in (10cm) wide. Z13–15 (min. 41°F/5°C)

F. setispinus. See *Thelocactus setispinus*.

F. wislizenii. Slow-growing, spherical, perennial cactus, columnar with age. H 6ft (2m), S 3ft (1m). Grayish-green stem, with up to 25 ribs, is covered in flattened, fish-hook, usually reddish-brown spines, to 2in (5cm) long. Funnel-shaped, orange or yellow flowers are produced in late summer, on plants over 10in (25cm) wide, which should attain this size 10–15 years after raising from seed. Z13–15 (min. 41°F/5°C)

FERRARIA

IRIDACEAE

Genus of spring-flowering corms, grown for their curious, malodorous, short-lived flowers, which are pollinated by flies. Flowers are iris-shaped with crisped margins to the petals. Requires full sun and well-drained soil. Plant in fall, water during winter, and dry off after flowering. Dies down in summer. Propagate by division in late summer or by seed in fall.

F. crispa, syn. *F. undulata*, illus. p.407.

F. undulata. See *F. crispa*.

FERULA

Giant fennel

APIACEAE/UMBELLIFERAE

Genus of mainly summer-flowering perennials, grown for their architectural form. Not to be confused with the culinary fennel, *Foeniculum*. Suitable for the back of a border, or as a specimen plant in a wild garden. Needs sun and well-drained soil. Sow seed when fresh, in late summer.

F. communis (Giant fennel) illus. p.219.

FESTUCA

POACEAE/GRAMINEAE

See also GRASSES, BAMBOOS, RUSHES, and SEDGES.

F. glauca (Blue fescue, Gray fescue). Evergreen, tuft-forming, perennial grass. H and S to 1ft (30cm). Has arching or erect, narrow, linear, inrolled, blue-green leaves. In summer, produces panicles, to 4in (10cm) long, with spikelets of violet-flushed, blue-green flowers. Good for edging. Z4–8. Leaves of ‘**Elijah Blue**’ are vivid blue. ‘**Golden Toupee**’ is semievergreen with bright yellow-green leaves.

FICARIA

Lesser celandine

RANUNCULACEAE

Genus of low-growing, herbaceous perennials, grown for their early spring flowers. Originally considered to be part of *Ranunculus* (buttercups), molecular research has now shown that *F. verna* and 3 other closely related species are genetically distinct. Grow *F. verna* in full sun or partial shade, in moist soil, but do not over-water. Propagate by division in spring or fall, or sow seed in spring. Good for a wild garden or under trees, but can be invasive. ☹ All species are poisonous.

F. verna, syn. *Ranunculus ficaria* (Lesser celandine, Pilewort). Clump-forming, very variable, tuberous perennial. H 2in (5cm), S to 1ft (30cm). The basal, heart-shaped, scalloped or toothed, glossy, dark green leaves wither after flowering. In early spring, produces shallowly cup-shaped, brilliant golden-yellow flowers, ¼–2in (2–5cm) across, that age to white. Z4–8.

var. albus (syn. *Ranunculus ficaria* var. *albus*) illus. p.349. **var. aurantiacus** (syn. *Ranunculus ficaria* var. *aurantiacus*) illus. p.359. ‘**Brazen Hussy**’ has heart-shaped, purple-bronze leaves and glossy, sulfur-yellow flowers, bronze on the reverse.

Flore Pleno Group (syn. *Ranunculus ficaria* ‘Flore Pleno’, *Ranunculus ficaria* var. *flore-pleno*) illus. p.357.

FICUS

MORACEAE

Genus of deciduous or mainly evergreen trees, shrubs and woody, scrambling or root climbers, grown for their foliage and to provide shade; a few species also for their fruit. All bear insignificant clusters of flowers in spring or summer. Prefers full light or partial shade and fertile, well-drained soil. Water containerized specimens moderately, very little when temperatures are low. Propagate by seed in spring or by leaf-bud or stem-tip cuttings or air-layering in summer. Red spider mite may be a nuisance. ☹ The foliage may cause mild stomach upset if ingested; the sap may irritate skin and eyes and may aggravate allergies.

F. benghalensis (Banyan) illus. p.452.

F. benjamina (Weeping fig). Evergreen, weeping tree or large shrub, often with aerial roots. H 100ft (30m), S to 50ft (15m) or more. Slender, ovate leaves, 2–5in (5–13cm) long, are a lustrous, rich green. Z10–11. (min. 50°F/10°C). ‘**Variegata**’ illus. p.450.

F. deltoidea (Mistletoe fig) illus. p.458.

F. elastica (India rubber fig, India rubber tree, Rubber plant). ‘**Decora**’ is a strong-growing, evergreen, irregularly ovoid tree. H to 100ft (30m), S 50–70ft (15–20m). Has broadly elliptic, leathery, lustrous, deep green leaves, red-flushed beneath, with creamy-white midribs. ‘**Doescheri**’ (Rubber plant) illus. p.450. Leaves of ‘**Variegata**’ are cream-margined, mottled with gray-green. Z14–15 (min. 59°F/15°C)

F. lyrata (Banjo fig, Fiddle-leaf fig) illus. p.452.

F. macrophylla (Australian banyan, Moreton Bay fig). Evergreen, wide-

spreading, dense tree with a buttressed trunk when mature. H 100–180ft (30–55m), S 70–130ft (20–40m). Ovate leaves, to 8in (20cm) long, are leathery, glossy, deep green. Z11–12 (min. 50°F/10°C)

F. pumila, syn. *F. repens* (Climbing fig, Creeping fig). Evergreen, root climber. H 25ft (8m), 5ft (1.5m) as a pot-grown plant. Bright, glossy green leaves are heart-shaped when young, leathery and ovate when mature. Unpalatable fruits are 2½in (6cm) long, green and white-spotted at first, then flushed red-purple. Only reaches adult stage in very warm regions or under glass. Pinch out branch tips to encourage branching. Z9–11. (min. 41°F/5°C). The leaves of ‘**Variegata**’ are irregularly margined in white.

F. repens. See *F. pumila*.

F. rubiginosa (Port Jackson fig). Evergreen, dense-headed tree with a buttressed trunk. H and S 50ft (15m) or more. Oblong to elliptic or ovate leaves, to 4in (10cm) long, are glossy, dark green above, usually with rust-colored down beneath. Z14–15 (min 50–55°F/10–13°C)

FILIPENDULA

Meadowsweet

ROSACEAE

Genus of spring- and summer-flowering, rhizomatous perennials, grown for their plumes of tiny, fluffy, red, pink or white flowers. Most grow in full sun or partial shade, in moist but well-drained, leafy soil; some species (such as *F. rubra*) will thrive in boggy sites. *F. vulgaris* needs a drier site, in full sun. Propagate by seed in fall or by division in fall or spring.

F. camtschatica, syn. *F. kamtschatica*. Clump-forming perennial. H to 5ft (1.5m), S 3ft (1m). In midsummer, produces frothy, flat heads of scented, star-shaped, white or pale pink flowers above large, lance-shaped, pinnate leaves. Z3–9

F. hexapetala. See *F. vulgaris*. ‘**Flore Pleno**’ see *F. vulgaris* ‘Multiplex’.

F. kamtschatica. See *F. camtschatica*.

F. palmata ‘**Rosea**’ of gardens. See *F. rubra* ‘Venus’.

F. palmata ‘**Rubra**’ of gardens. See *F. purpurea*.

F. purpurea, syn. *F. palmata* ‘Rubra’ of gardens, illus. p.238.

F. rubra illus. p.438. ‘**Venusta**’ (syn. *F. palmata* ‘Rosea’ of gardens) is a spreading perennial, forming large clumps in moist soil. H 6–8ft (1.8–2.5m), S 4ft (1.2m). Has pinnate, irregularly cut leaves, with toothed leaflets. In early and mid-summer, branched stems bear deep rose-pink flowers that age to pale pink. Z3–9

F. ulmaria, syn. *Spiraea ulmaria* (Meadowsweet), illus. p.436. Z5–9.

‘**Aurea**’ illus. p.274.

F. vulgaris, syn. *F. hexapetala* (Dropwort). ‘**Multiplex**’ (syn. *F. hexapetala* ‘Flore Pleno’) is an upright, rosette-forming perennial with fleshy, swollen roots. H 3ft (1m), S 1½ft (45cm). In summer, bronze buds open to flat heads of rounded, double, sometimes pendent, creamy-white flowers, above fernlike, finely divided, toothed, hairless, dark green leaves. Z4–7

FIRMIANA

MALVACEAE

Genus of deciduous trees and shrubs, grown for their foliage and to provide shade. To reach tree proportions, needs min. 36–41°F (2–5°C). Requires well-drained but moisture-retentive, fertile soil and full light or partial shade. Water containerized specimens freely when in full growth, less in winter. Pruning is tolerated if necessary. Propagate by seed when ripe or in spring.

F. platanifolia. See *F. simplex*.

F. simplex, syn. *F. platanifolia*, *Sterculia platanifolia* (Chinese parasol tree), illus. p.451.

FITTONIA

Nerve plant, Painted net leaf

ACANTHACEAE

Genus of evergreen, creeping perennials, grown mainly for their foliage. Useful as groundcover. Frost tender. Needs a fairly humid atmosphere. Grow in shade and well-drained soil; keep well watered but avoid waterlogging, especially in winter. Cut back straggly plants in spring. Propagate in spring or summer, with extra heat, by division or stem cuttings.

F. albivenis **Argyroneura Group**, syn. *F. argyroneura* (Silver net leaf), illus. p.468.

Verschaffeltii Group (syn. *F. verschaffeltii*) is an evergreen, creeping perennial. H to 6in (15cm), S indefinite. Produces small, ovate, red-veined, olive-green leaves; any flowers that form are best removed. Z14–15 (min. 59°F/15°C)

F. argyroneura. See *F. albivenis* **Argyroneura Group**.

F. verschaffeltii. See *F. albivenis* **Verschaffeltii Group**.

FITZROYA

CUPRESSACEAE

See also CONIFERS.

F. cupressoides, syn. *F. patagonica* (Patagonian cypress), illus. p.100.

F. patagonica. See *F. cupressoides*.

FOENICULUM

Fennel

APIACEAE/UMBELLIFERAE

Genus of one species of summer-flowering perennial, grown for its flowers and for its leaves, which are decorative and used for culinary flavouring. Grow in an open, sunny site, in fertile, well-drained soil. Remove flower heads after fading to stop self seeding. Propagate by seed in spring.

F. vulgare (Fennel). ‘**Bronze**’ see *F.v. ‘Purpureum’*. ‘**Purpureum**’ (syn. *F.v. ‘Bronze*’) is an erect, branching perennial. H 6ft (2m), S 1½ft (45cm). Produces very finely divided, hairlike, bronze leaves and, in summer, large, flat umbels of small, yellow flowers. Z6–9

FORSYTHIA

OLEACEAE

Genus of mainly deciduous, sometimes semievergreen, spring-flowering shrubs, grown for their usually profuse, yellow flowers, which are produced before the